

Back to the drawing board

As an avid sci-fi fan, I often find myself involved in arguments about the future. One especially sensitive topic for us journalists is the print vs. new media debate. One faction of purists believes that nothing will ever replace print, while others argue that print is destined to die at some point in time, and mobiles, TVs and the web are the only way forward. Of course you'd expect that as a magazine's editor I'd be biased towards print... and perhaps I am, a little. I certainly still believe that there's no better and more comfortable reading experience than a good book or magazine, and the only digital device that comes close thus far is my Kindle.

However, you already know this, since you're reading this on physical paper to begin with. It's the relaxed, unhurried nature of the medium that perhaps appeals most. One look at a site, or worse a TV program, and you know that you're being bombarded with too much information. TV also suffers from the handicap of being sequential, where you just cannot skip past the stuff you're not interested in. The web has no sequential problems, but it does need you to turn on a device to access content. The mobile web, if anything is the most promising medium, because a mobile device isn't considered a luxury; it's something you need. However, size ruins the viewing experience significantly there. Tablets are a stop gap solution to that, but they're still big and bulky, expensive, and run out of juice constantly.

Even if everyone agreed with these points, would it stop the masses from spending through their noses to buy such devices? Of course not; the world has gone digital in a huge way, and everything is stored on hard drives, DVDs, and tape drives. It's almost impossible for any of us to think of getting a project for school or work done without the help of technology.

Wikipedia, Google, Facebook, YouTube, etc., all host trillions of GBs of data, some of it actually valuable, and the backups of said data is always additional technology-based storage. We're excited to be moving towards the cloud, with storage, OSes and everything other than the hardware in our hands moving online. All spaced out geographically, but all in the same place, in a sense, since the servers are all connected. What if a global catastrophe occurred? A technology apocalypse of sorts – a mega solar flare, or nuclear doomsday brought on ourselves... perhaps even a super-virus that could bypass everything and just destroy all our data, what then?

Since most of the civilisations of our past perished, I don't think we should be naive enough to think that such a thing could never happen to us. It was all the stone tablets and plant fibre based papers that we unearthed in archaeological digs that gave us an insight into the past – our past. Without those physical forms of expression (letters, numbers and drawings), would we be able to figure out their languages?

If the apocalypse were to occur, I wonder what future historians and archaeologists will think of us when they find remnants of our civilisation. How will they decipher dead hard drives, DVDs and USB sticks when they discover them? It's hard enough for us to extract data from such devices that die on us, so how will people who may not even know our language (just as we didn't know the Mayan's language) figure out anything about us?

This is where paper comes in; and no, not the paper this magazine is printed on, but super paper. Kind of like the paper that a company called DuPont, for example, has come up with. It's called Tyvek, and is un-tearable and water resistant, allows air to pass through (unlike plastic sheets), and get this, is also recyclable! Thus, it can be used to store prints that would last eons, and is even useful for making long lasting covers and has medical implications too. More details at dupont.com.

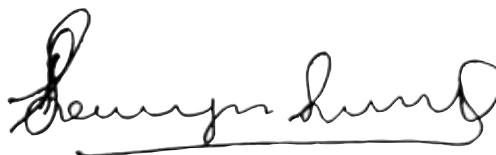
Of course, we can't go backing up GBs of personal data on it – the Facebook wall history kind – but we can certainly backup all of our collective scientific knowledge to such a medium so as to protect our future, just in case... Maybe we could backup the contents of archive.org and Wikipedia on such a medium; and why shouldn't we? There are some humans frozen in time in liquid nitrogen, awaiting a re-birth, and we've had the idea of time capsules for decades now. Perhaps it's finally time to go back to drawing board, per se, and keep some physical documentation of the history of humanity safe; and while we're at it, do the same on a more personal level, ensuring that we're not completely handicapped without technology – and keep our books and magazines safe.

Just maybe that's some food for thought for those who think paper is *dead*... 



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